

Choosing a Care Home

A simple, no-pressure guide to finding the right home for someone you love.

Choosing a care home is one of the most important — and emotional — decisions a family makes. This guide breaks it down into manageable steps so you can move forward with confidence.

1. Work out the type of care needed

- **Residential care** — help with everyday things like washing, dressing, meals and medication.
- **Nursing care** — 24-hour care from registered nurses for ongoing medical needs.
- **Dementia care** — specialist support in calm, familiar surroundings.
- **Respite & short stays** — short-term care, or a trial stay to see if a home feels right.
- **End-of-life care** — gentle, dignified care working with your GP and family.

Tip: needs often change over time. A home that offers several types of care under one roof means a move into nursing or dementia care rarely means moving home.

2. Always visit — more than once

A home can look perfect online and feel different in person. Drop in, stay for lunch, and visit at a quieter time too. Notice the warmth between staff and residents — it tells you more than any brochure.

3. Questions worth asking

- What is the staff-to-resident ratio, day and night?
- How are care plans created and reviewed with families?
- What activities and outings are on offer?
- How is food prepared, and are special diets catered for?
- Can residents bring their own furniture and belongings?
- What are the visiting arrangements?
- What are the fees, and what exactly do they include?

4. Check the regulator

Every care home in England is registered with and inspected by the Care Quality Commission (CQC). You can read each home's latest inspection report free at [cqc.org.uk](https://www.cqc.org.uk).

Your visit checklist

- ✓ The home feels clean, bright and homely
- ✓ Staff are warm and know residents by name
- ✓ Residents look comfortable and engaged
- ✓ There is a clear activities programme
- ✓ Bedrooms can be personalised
- ✓ Gardens or outdoor space are accessible
- ✓ You feel listened to and your questions are answered openly

This guide is general information and not financial or medical advice. To arrange a visit or ask anything at all, call **Venza Care UK on 0800 470 1925** (Mon–Sun, 8am–8pm) or visit venzacare.co.uk.